



Gaming Laptops

Gaming laptops, as a genre, has shrunk considerably this year. With mainstream laptops closing in, at least in terms of performance and being considerably more affordable, most consumers are happy.

Albeit they are some levels lower in terms of performance, mainstream laptops and even ultrabooks are doing rather well with handling the latest games at more than acceptable frame-rates.

But not to be outdone, gaming notebooks have created a separate niche for themselves. Being pushed for performance, they have just taken the hardware and specifications to the next level. There still is a considerable amount of variety in this unique category. The likes of the Alienware still hope that its brand recall and aura will compensate for slightly lesser specs, while ASUS has completely gone hammer and tongs on the hardware with the G-series gaming laptops.

Not many manufacturers have a separate gaming laptop category in their range of offerings, with only Dell retaining its Alienware brand and ASUS giving it some competition. HP, on its part, has the Envy 15 that is a bit of a go-between a very powerful mainstream and an entry level gaming laptop. Hopefully, this will not be a trend going into 2013.

Zero1 Winner ASUS G75VW

This looks, feels and performs like a gaming laptop! It's quite heavy at 4.5 kg which may be partly due to the 17.3-inch Full HD display. The rest of its weight can be attributed to the specs – Intel Core i7-3610QM, 16 GB RAM, NVIDIA GeForce GTX670M (2 GB), 750 GB hard drive and a 256 GB Lite-on LAT-256M3S SSD on which Windows 7 is installed. The system performs well and the gaming scores were the best among all gaming machines. At almost ₹1,30,000 in the market, this does cost a lot of money. The Alienware M17x, its direct rival, with similar specifications costs almost ₹1,62,000. What the ASUS rig misses out on is the visual experience of colourful lighting that has become a trademark of Alienware machines. The ASUS G75VW is by far the best gaming laptop out there and despite any eye-candy, deserves the Zero1 award for the sheer performance chops.

Worthy mentions

Dell Alienware M14x

When Dell sent us the updated M14x, we were a tad surprised that they did not nominate the M17x for



▲ ASUS G75VW

Price: ₹1,29,999

the awards. Maybe that is where they went wrong, because this effort is strong enough for a second place. But there is a logic behind the M14x. Dell's idea was to offer an almost similar spec sheet and an equally powerful experience in a form factor that is more compact, somewhat portable and yet doesn't sacrifice any of Alienware's trademarks – the grilles, the colourful keyboard, customisable LED lights, etc. There are two M14x versions available in the market, and the one that we received costs around ₹95,000 and the spec sheet looks somewhat like this – Intel Core i7-3630QM, 6 GB RAM, 14-inch (1600 x 900 pixel) display, NVIDIA GeForce GT650M and a 750GB hard drive.



Dell Alienware M14x

Price: ₹95,237 (excl. tax)



HP Envy 4-1002tx

Price: ₹56,000

HP Envy 4-1002tx

We never thought we would say this, but this is the machine that set the affordable ultrabook segment alight with unmatched performance. The benchmark scores are proof of its excellent system performance. Its build quality is also undisputedly the best among ultrabooks in its category. But the real kicker is the AMD Radeon HD 7670M (2 GB) graphics, which ensures that the Envy 4 scores the highest gaming scores among all ultrabooks costing less than ₹75,000. Yes, it is an ultrabook, which means you will get excellent battery life rest of the time. Get this, if you want the best of both worlds – the gaming bit while retaining the complete flexibility of portability and battery life.